



The summit vent of Mount Etna, an active volcano on the east coast of Sicily, in Italy, has witnessed many destructive eruptions, not least in 1693.

IF SOUTHERN EUROPE

had been spared the worst of the Little Ice Age (see 1683–84), the eruption on January 11, 1693 of **Mount Etna**, in Sicily, proved a cruel reminder of the power of nature. The eruption **set off an earthquake** that **devastated Sicily** and large areas of southern Italy and Malta. About 60,000 were killed in Sicily alone, and thousands of square miles became uninhabitable due to lava flows and tsunamis.

For several years after the summer of 1693, a series of **famines swept western Europe**. In France alone, about two million died. These were among the most calamitous **consequences of the Little Ice Age**, with bitter winters giving way to dismal, rain-soaked summers, and stunted crops rotting in sodden fields. Even in years of relative plenty, the vast **majority of Europe's peasants**, themselves the overwhelming majority of the continent's population, had a subsistence existence at best, with root vegetables, bread, and oatmeal as their staple diet. When the crops failed, they starved. In the face of these near Biblical visitations of mass misery, there seemed to be no answer. Almost entirely dependent on the food surpluses generated by its heavily taxed peasant population, even as obviously powerful a state as late-17th-century France could do



Dodo

The dodo stood about 3 ft 3 in (1 m) in height and weighed about 44 lb (20 kg). It had a long, hooked bill, grayish or brownish plumage on a fat body, and very small wings.

little more than suffer and accept its unavoidable fate.

In 1598, on the **isolated island of Mauritius**, in the Indian Ocean, the Dutch admiral Wybrand van Warwijck described a bird he called a "walghvogel." Later Dutch settlers there called it a "dodaars," which was a reference to what they saw as the knot of tails at its rear. Portuguese sailors that visited the island called it a "doudo," meaning "fool" or "crazy." By perhaps 1693, the **dodo**, a **flightless bird** that was related to the pigeon, had **become extinct**. The dodo is the first animal whose extinction can be specifically ascribed to man; it was a victim of its trusting nature, the destruction of its woodland habitats, and the introduction of cats, rats, pigs, and dogs that hunted it to its extinction.



The forces of the Grand Alliance, led by William III of England, gather outside Namur, where a French garrison is besieged. The siege lasted two months.

IN JULY 1694, ENGLAND FOUND A

NOVEL SOLUTION to the problem of a lack of funds that had plagued the combatants of the Nine Years' War. The **Bank of England** served both Crown and government, and was closely modeled on the Bank of Amsterdam, founded in 1609. A private venture (until 1931), it **immediately loaned the government** £1.2 million—raised by its investors in 12 days—at an annual interest rate of 8 percent and for an annual service charge of £4,000, in return for the right to print bank notes. It also **created a National Debt**, but at the same time allowed England not merely to finance its own part in the war but to finance its allies. The bank was possibly the most significant factor in Britain's subsequent emergence on the world stage.

European colonialism in the 17th and 18th centuries had the simple goal of money. In the New World, the Spanish had conquered two rich civilizations and found a vast silver mine. The **Portuguese in Brazil** had found only native peoples and tropical jungles; sugarcane plantations worked by slave labor were the source of its marginal profits. Then, in **Minas Gerais**, in the southeast, **gold was found** in 1695. It transformed colonial Brazil, as did the later discovery of diamonds in the same region. Vast, lawless towns appeared, chiefly Ouro Preto

("Black Gold") and Diamantia, and the region's **population exploded**, from scattered handfuls to 320,000 (half of them slaves). A result was the near collapse of the sugarcane industry, stripped of most of its workforce.

One of the few moments of significance in the Nine Years' War took place in September 1695, when the **Grand Alliance retook the city of Namur** after three years in French hands. The loss of the most important fortress in the Netherlands further weakened an already defensive French position.

In 1696, **China** began an **eastward expansion** that by the end of the 18th century would see it **almost double in size**. It was provoked by the invasion of Khalkha (Outer Mongolia) by the nomadic Zunghar people of Central Asia in 1690, who were anxious to forestall a possible Chinese takeover of the region. The **invasion failed**, sparking only a confused series of campaigns under the Zunghar ruler, Galdan, as well as a civil war. In 1696, the Kangxi Emperor led a Khalkha-Chinese army across the Gobi Desert into Mongolia and crushed the Zunghar. **Outer Mongolia was incorporated within the Chinese empire** the following year.

Russia fought two campaigns in 1695–96 to capture the **Ottoman-held fortress port of Azov**. The port was key to Russia because it



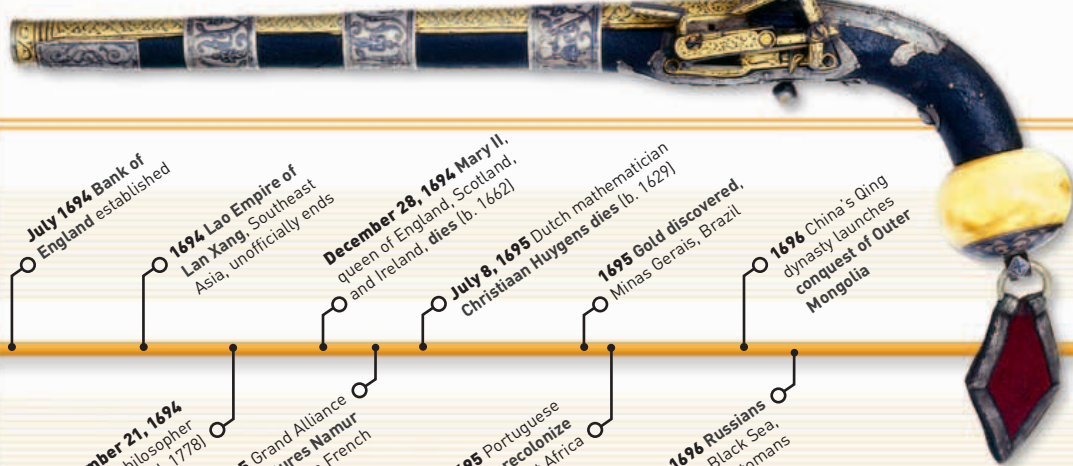
Battle of Azov

In this painting by Robert Kerr Porter, Peter the Great is seen personally leading his galley fleet during the capture of Azov in 1696.

blocked access to the Black Sea, a factor that had contributed to the failure of its Crimean campaigns against the Ottomans in 1687–89. Finally, Peter I (the Great), the sole czar of Russia since the death of his disabled half-brother, Ivan, attacked Azov with a combined land and naval force, capturing the city in July 1696. A lesson learned was that Russia needed a navy, and it embarked on a massive shipbuilding program.

Caucasian pistol

This ornately fashioned pistol with a long barrel and a short, gently curved handle was typical of the weaponry employed in the Azov campaigns.



January 11 Eruption of Mount Etna, Sicily

Grand Alliance defeated by French, at Neerwinden, Flanders

Portuguese expelled from Zimbabwe

Kingston, Jamaica, founded

Great Famine begins in Europe; millions die

Diego de Vargas completes reconquest of New Mexico for Spain

October French capture Charleroi in Nine Years' War

Approximate date of extinction of dodo, Mauritius

July 1694 Bank of England established

November 21, 1694 French philosopher Voltaire born (d. 1778)

1694 Lao Empire of Lan Xang, Southeast Asia, unofficially ends

December 28, 1694 Mary II, queen of England, Scotland, and Ireland, dies (b. 1662)

July 8, 1695 Dutch mathematician Christian Huygens dies (b. 1629)

1695 Gold discovered, Minas Gerais, Brazil

1695 Portuguese attempt to recolonize southeast Africa

July 1696 Russians take Azov, Black Sea, from Ottomans

1696 China's Qing dynasty launches conquest of Outer Mongolia